THE PHOTOGRAPHIC FIELD GUIDE

Make the photograph.

Six scenes. A good starting point.



SET. SHOOT. ADJUST.

Practical camera settings, precise focus targets and useful fixes, ready when the scene is in front of you.

FREE SAMPLE

A4 digital & print companion / 2026

HOW TO USE YOUR GUIDE

Start with the scene.

Choose the photograph you want to make. Read the light and subject assumptions, set the starting values, then inspect a test frame. The small adjustments make the difference.

01 Match the conditions

A night street, a bright stage and a moonlit sky need different exposures. Start with the sheet that matches both the subject and the light.

02 Set the camera

ISO, aperture and shutter are a coherent starting combination. In M + Auto ISO, you set aperture and shutter; the camera chooses ISO within the shown bounds. The estimate is not a fixed instruction.

03 Put focus in the right place

The focus target matters as much as the exposure. Follow the instruction under Focus, then check the recorded image enlarged.

04 Read the photograph

Check movement, important highlights and sharpness. Use the symptom-to-adjustment pairs to make the next frame better.

Your camera format. Lens lengths in this guide describe a full-frame equivalent field of view. Divide by 1.5 or 1.6 for APS-C, or by 2 for Micro Four Thirds, to choose a similar actual focal length. Exposure values do not change just because sensor size changes.

A compact companion. This edition condenses each scene into one practical camera sheet. The free app contains additional alternatives, explanations, capability-aware phone advice, lens-limit adaptation and tools. Use the linked scene for the full treatment.

About the photographs. Real, licensed photographs show the subject or atmosphere. They are visual references; the nearby recipes are original starting setups, not claimed capture metadata for the photographs. Crop, season, light and equipment will change your result.

Print only the sheets you need. Use A4 paper at actual size (100%) or fit to your printer's paper. On a phone or tablet, use the PDF bookmarks to jump straight to a scene.

Open the complete Fieldframe app · Updated 30 October 2026



Photo: Photo Tours Peru / Visual reference. Settings below are starting recommendations.

Milky Way

A clear dark sky, with the bright galactic region above the local horizon and no strong moonlight washing it out. Visibility depends on date, latitude and hemisphere.

ISO	APERTURE	SHUTTER	SUPPORT
3200	f/2.8	10 s	Tripod

M · **20 mm equivalent** · 3800 K starting point; RAW · ISO is set manually.

Start at 10 s. Use the star estimator with actual focal length and pixel pitch. Shorten if stars stretch; raise ISO before extending a motion-limited shutter.

FOCUS

Magnify a bright star in live view and turn the focus ring until its core is smallest. Check centre and corner stars in an enlarged recorded frame.

MAKE THE FRAME

1. Check clouds, Moon position, darkness and galactic visibility for the exact location and date.

2. Choose a safe foreground in daylight and keep lamps out of the composition.

3. Secure the tripod, select RAW and focus manually on a magnified star.

4. Take the 10 s test and enlarge stars at the centre and corners.

5. Shorten shutter for directional trails; refocus round swollen stars; stop down slightly for wing-shaped corner aberrations.

6. If a near foreground is unsharp, make a separately focused frame and disclose any later blend.

TAKE WITH YOU

Camera with manual exposure · Wide lens and tripod

Useful: Remote/timer · Dew control · Spare battery

IF THIS HAPPENS, ADJUST THIS

Stars are short lines

Shorten shutter and raise ISO to restore brightness.

Stars are round but swollen

Refocus under magnification and inspect the front element.

Corner stars look like wings

Try f/3.2-4 and raise ISO while preserving shutter time.

Sky is orange and flat

Change location, direction or timing; avoid exposing the sky into clipping.

ONE THING TO TRY

Check corners as well as the centre: one sharp central star does not prove the whole wide-open frame is clean.

Open the full scene, alternatives & sources

Intermediate / Starting values: test and adjust

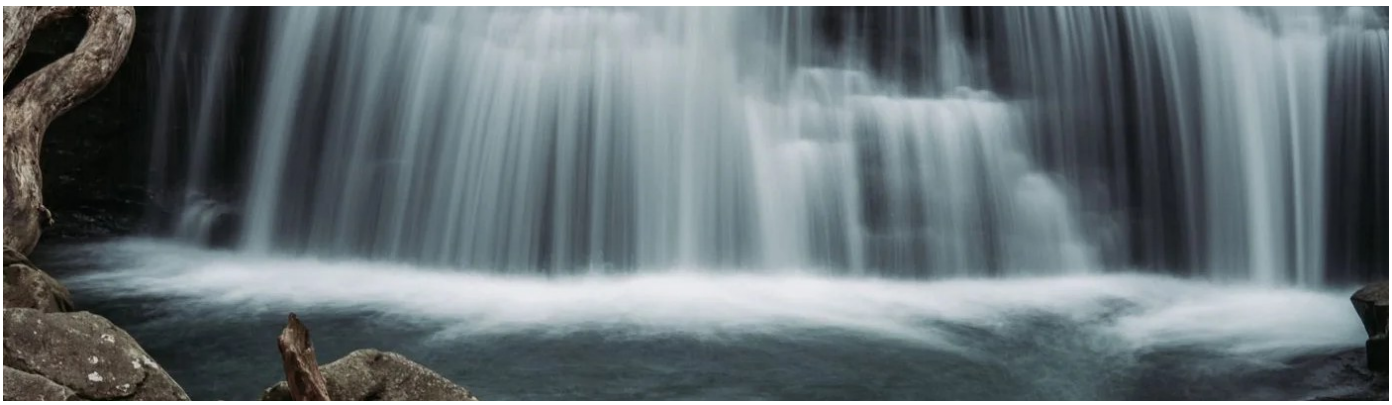


Photo: Connor Scott McManus / Visual reference. Settings below are starting recommendations.

Silky waterfall

A waterfall in soft shade or overcast light, with stable rocks and no important wind-blown leaves.

ISO	APERTURE	SHUTTER	SUPPORT
100	f/8	1/2 s	Tripod

M · **35 mm equivalent** · Daylight or Cloudy · ISO is set manually.

Start at 1/2 s and inspect the flow. Use an ND filter if the meter requires a shorter exposure at f/8 and base ISO; calculate its strength from the unfiltered exposure.

FOCUS

Focus on a stationary rock at the main waterfall plane, then lock focus before adding a very dark ND filter.

MAKE THE FRAME

1. Find a safe dry position and a flow pattern with interesting rock edges.

2. Frame away from distracting bright sky and sunlit white water.

3. Focus on a rock, take an unfiltered meter/test frame and add ND only as needed.

4. Expose at 1/2 s with a timer.

5. Check rock sharpness and white water detail separately.

6. Shorten for more texture or lengthen for smoother flow, compensating exposure with ND/aperture as appropriate.

TAKE WITH YOU

Tripod · Camera with controllable exposure

Useful: ND filter appropriate to light · Polariser for wet-rock glare · Lens cloth and rain protection

IF THIS HAPPENS, ADJUST THIS

Water is blank white

Reduce exposure first; shorten shutter for more internal texture.

Rocks are soft too

Stabilise the tripod and refocus on a stationary edge.

Leaves are blurred but rocks sharp

Wait for calm, crop the leaves or use a shorter shutter.

Image too bright at base ISO

Add measured ND strength; do not rely on f/22 as the only solution.

ONE THING TO TRY

The right shutter depends on water speed and framing: try 1/8, 1/2 and 2 seconds before deciding that smoother is better.

SAFETY FIRST. Stay on safe dry ground. Wet rock, spray and fast water are hazardous; do not climb into a risky position for the composition.

Open the full scene, alternatives & sources

Easy / Starting values: test and adjust



Photo: Natha KP / Visual reference. Settings below are starting recommendations.

Bird in flight

A bird crossing open sky or a distant background in daylight.

ISO	APERTURE	SHUTTER	SUPPORT
Auto ~800	f/5.6	1/3200 s	Handheld

M + Auto ISO · **500 mm equivalent** · Daylight, about 5200 K; RAW allows later refinement · Auto ISO bounds 100-12800.

Choose 1/3200 s and f/5.6; Auto ISO 100-12800 adapts to light. Larger gliding birds may allow 1/1600 s; small flapping birds can need 1/4000 s or faster.

FOCUS

Acquire the bird early with a suitable zone, then keep the detected eye or head in focus as you follow.

MAKE THE FRAME

1. Select a safe position with an unobstructed view and the light behind or beside you.

2. Set a focus-distance limiter only if the expected distance fits it.

3. Find the bird at a wider zoom setting if necessary.

4. Acquire tracking before starting a short burst.

5. Follow smoothly and leave room around the wings.

6. Check eye detail and wing blur separately; change shutter only for actual motion blur.

TAKE WITH YOU

Long telephoto lens · Continuous tracking AF

Useful: Shoulder strap or monopod · Lens hood

IF THIS HAPPENS, ADJUST THIS

Body sharp, wing tips blurred

Use 1/4000 s or faster if frozen tips are essential.

Bird lost against trees

Start on the bird before it crosses trees and reduce tracking switching sensitivity.

Wings clipped

Zoom out slightly and leave margin above and below.

Pale bird clips against dark trees

Reduce exposure compensation with Auto ISO if supported; otherwise use fixed ISO.

ONE THING TO TRY

Keep both eyes open while finding a distant bird; this can make initial acquisition easier with a long lens.

SAFETY FIRST. Avoid nesting areas and do not force a bird to fly for a photograph.

Open the full scene, alternatives & sources

Intermediate / Starting values: test and adjust

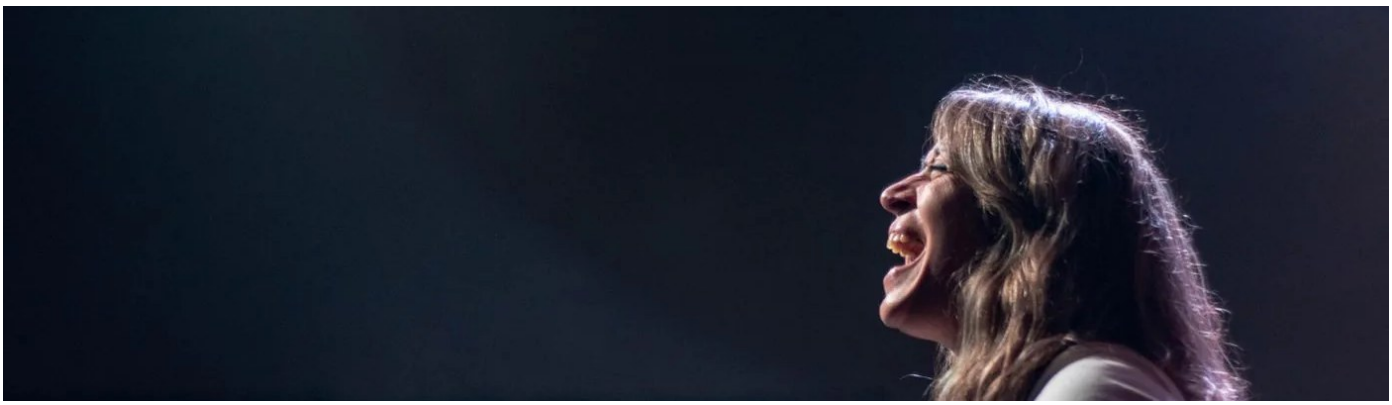


Photo: Franco Monsalvo / Visual reference. Settings below are starting recommendations.

Indoor concert performance

A moving musician under changing concert lights, photographed from permitted audience or press access.

ISO	APERTURE	SHUTTER	SUPPORT
Auto ~3200	f/2.8	1/320 s	Handheld

M + Auto ISO · **85 mm equivalent** · 4000 K starting point in RAW; preserve intentional colour · Auto ISO bounds 800-12800.

Keep 1/320 s for moderate movement and use 1/640 s for jumps. Auto ISO can range to 12800; if it reaches the ceiling, wait for a brighter light cue or use a faster lens.

FOCUS

Track the performer's lit eye; if coloured light defeats detection, place a small zone on the face or high-contrast clothing edge.

MAKE THE FRAME

1. Confirm the venue's camera, flash and access rules.

2. Watch a lighting cycle and anticipate when the face becomes visible.

3. Set continuous focus and a short burst; choose the starting shutter and aperture.

4. Track before the expression peaks and make several frames.

5. Check eye sharpness, skin highlights and coloured channel clipping.

6. Use faster shutter for moving hands; test shutter type or anti-flicker controls if bands appear.

TAKE WITH YOU

Camera permitted by the venue · Fast lens or main phone camera

Useful: Ear protection · Spare battery · Longer lens for restricted access

IF THIS HAPPENS, ADJUST THIS

Microphone sharp, face soft

Start tracking on the face beside the microphone or use a smaller zone.

Eyes sharp but hands smear

Use 1/640 s and raise ISO.

Skin turns featureless red

Lower exposure and wait for a mixed or white light cue.

Dark stripes cross performer

Test mechanical shutter, anti-flicker or variable shutter where supported; inspect test frames.

ONE THING TO TRY

Listen for repeated musical phrases; the strongest gesture and the lighting cue often repeat together.

Open the full scene, alternatives & sources

Advanced / Starting values: test and adjust



Photo: Pixabay / Visual reference. Settings below are starting recommendations.

Night street, handheld

After dark on a street with illuminated shop windows or pools of lamp light; pedestrians are moving.

ISO	APERTURE	SHUTTER	SUPPORT
Auto ~3200	f/2	1/250 s	Handheld

M + Auto ISO · **35 mm equivalent** · 3800 K starting point; RAW if available · Auto ISO bounds 800-12800.

Keep 1/250 s for walkers. Open to f/1.8 if available; let Auto ISO rise to 12800 before accepting motion blur. Seek brighter light if the ceiling is reached.

FOCUS

Track the face as it reaches a lit area; use a small AF point on a contrast edge if eye detection fails.

MAKE THE FRAME

1. Find a well-lit patch with an uncluttered background.

2. Set RAW if supported and turn off flash.

3. Choose 1/250 s, f/2 and Auto ISO; set a realistic upper limit.

4. Focus on the person in the light and make several short bursts.

5. Inspect eyes, bright signs and the red/blue channels if your camera shows them.

6. If the face is underexposed at the ISO ceiling, wait for a brighter position or use f/1.8.

TAKE WITH YOU

Fast lens or main phone camera · Strap

Useful: Lens hood · Spare battery

IF THIS HAPPENS, ADJUST THIS

Face streaks while signs are sharp

Use 1/500 s for brisk movement and accept higher ISO.

All light edges wobble

Brace your stance and keep 1/250 s or faster.

Face is soft but coat lettering is sharp

Place a small AF point on the lit eye or nearest facial edge.

Neon turns flat white

Lower exposure with Auto ISO compensation or manual ISO; do not judge only the average histogram.

ONE THING TO TRY

Watch where a lamp catches the eyes; a half-step into that light can outperform a much more expensive lens.

Open the full scene, alternatives & sources

Intermediate / Starting values: test and adjust



Photo: Kian Mousazadeh / Visual reference. Settings below are starting recommendations.

Portrait beside a window

A person beside a large window with indirect daylight and little competing room light.

ISO	APERTURE	SHUTTER	SUPPORT
800	f/2.8	1/200 s	Handheld

M · **50 mm equivalent** · Daylight or custom balance from the window light · ISO is set manually.

Keep 1/200 s for small movements. Raise ISO as the person moves farther from the window; use f/4 and more ISO if both eyes need greater depth.

FOCUS

Place focus on the near eye and check the far eye if the head is strongly turned.

MAKE THE FRAME

1. Choose indirect window light or diffuse direct sun with a sheer curtain.

2. Turn off room lights that cast a conflicting colour.

3. Seat the person near the window and rotate the face toward its light.

4. Focus on the near eye and take a test.

5. Check catchlights, the shadow-side eye and bright cheek texture.

6. Use a white card for gentle fill or move the person closer to the window before relying on a slower shutter.

TAKE WITH YOU

Window with useful daylight · Camera or phone

Useful: White card/reflector · Sheer curtain

IF THIS HAPPENS, ADJUST THIS

Shadow eye vanishes

Rotate toward the window or add a nearby white reflector.

One side is orange and the other blue

Turn off conflicting lamps or deliberately balance both light sources.

Near eye sharp, far eye soft

Use f/4 and raise ISO or reduce the angle.

Whole face lacks sharpness but chair is sharp

Use 1/250-1/400 s and increase ISO.

ONE THING TO TRY

A catchlight tells you the eye can see the window; if it disappears, change the face angle before changing exposure.

Open the full scene, alternatives & sources

Easy / Starting values: test and adjust

THE PHOTOGRAPHERS BEHIND THE SCENES

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A Cascading Waterfalls Near Rocks · Pexels License

003 Bird in flight / Natha KP
A Brown Hawk Flying in the Air · Pexels License

004 Indoor concert performance / Franco Monsalvo
Blonde Woman Singing on Stage · Pexels License

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People Standing at the Alley · Pexels License

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Man in Shirt by Window · Pexels License

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